
**Ergonomics of human-system
interaction —**

**Part 11:
Usability: Definitions and concepts**

Ergonomie de l'interaction homme-système —

Partie 11: Utilisabilité — Définitions et concepts



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Ergonomics of human-system interaction —

Part 11: Usability: Definitions and concepts

1 Scope

This document provides a framework for understanding the concept of usability and applying it to situations where people use interactive systems, and other types of systems (including built environments), and products (including industrial and consumer products) and services (including technical and personal services).

NOTE In this document, the phrase “object of interest” refers to the system, product or service for which usability is being considered (see [8.1](#)).

This document:

- explains that usability is an outcome of use;
- defines key terms and concepts;
- identifies the fundamentals of usability; and
- explains the application of the concept of usability.

It does not describe specific processes or methods for taking account of usability in design development or evaluation.

The intended users of this document include:

- usability/ergonomics/human factors professionals;
- designers and developers of systems, products and services;
- quality assurance personnel;
- public and corporate purchasers; and
- consumer organizations.

The most common applications of this document are in design and evaluation.

2 Normative references

There are no normative references in this document.

3 Terms and definitions

For the purposes of this document, the following terms and definitions apply.

ISO and IEC maintain terminological databases for use in standardization at the following addresses:

- ISO Online browsing platform: available at <https://www.iso.org/obp>
- IEC Electropedia: available at <https://www.electropedia.org/>

3.1 Usability

3.1.1 usability

extent to which a system, product or service can be used by specified users to achieve specified goals with effectiveness, efficiency and satisfaction in a specified context of use

Note 1 to entry: The “specified” users, goals and context of use refer to the particular combination of users, goals and context of use for which usability is being considered.

Note 2 to entry: The word “usability” is also used as a qualifier to refer to the design knowledge, competencies, activities and design attributes that contribute to usability, such as usability expertise, usability professional, usability engineering, usability method, usability evaluation, usability heuristic.

[SOURCE: ISO 9241-210:2010, 2.13, modified — Notes 1 and 2 were added.]

3.1.2 product

item that is made or created by a person or machine

3.1.3 consumer product

product that is intended to be acquired and used by an individual for personal rather than professional use

[SOURCE: ISO 20282-1:2006, 3.2]

3.1.4 system

combination of interacting elements organized to achieve one or more stated purposes

Note 1 to entry: A system is sometimes considered as a product or as the services it provides.

Note 2 to entry: A complete system includes all of the associated equipment, facilities, material, computer programs, firmware, technical documentation, services and personnel required for operations and support to the degree necessary for self-sufficient use in its intended environment.

Note 3 to entry: A system can be composed of a product, service, built environment or combination thereof, and people.

[SOURCE: ISO/IEC 15288:2015, 4.1.46, modified — Notes 2 and 3 have been replaced.]

3.1.5 interactive system

combination of hardware and/or software and/or services and/or people that users interact with in order to achieve specific goals

Note 1 to entry: This includes, where appropriate, packaging, user documentation, on-line and human help, support and training.

[SOURCE: ISO 9241-210:2010, 2.8, modified]

3.1.6 service

means of delivering value for the customer by facilitating results the customer wants to achieve

Note 1 to entry: Services can include both human-system interactions (e.g. accessing a word processor through the web) and human-human interactions (e.g. a citizen interacting with a clerk at the post office counter).

Note 2 to entry: The “customer” is a user, and does not necessarily have a financial relationship.

[SOURCE: ISO/IEC 20000-1:2011, 3.26, modified — The notes have been replaced.]